Rebecca: Writer's Methods & Techniques

Exam code: 0475 & 0992

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Writer's Methods and Techniques

"Writer's methods and techniques" is an umbrella term for anything the writer does on purpose to create meaning. Using the writer's name in your response will help you to think about the text as a conscious construct and will keep reminding you that du Maurier purposely put the text together.

The best responses at IGCSE don't limit their analysis to individual words and phrases. Examiners are really looking for analysis of du Maurier's overall aims, so try to take a "whole-text" approach to writer's methods and techniques. There are a number of methods and techniques used in Rebecca:

- **Unreliable first-person narrator**
- **Bildungsroman**
- **The Gothic**
- **Symbolism**
- **Suspense genre**

Unreliable first-person narrator

- The narrative is told from the perspective of the unnamed narrator, the second Mrs de Winter:
  - Her first-person perspective, in addition to her emotional state and insecurities, control and shape the narrative
  - Her insecurity is exacerbated by the continual comparisons with Rebecca and these influence her interpretations of events
  - Her fragility and heightened emotions also contribute to her unreliability as a narrator
- Du Maurier's deliberate choice to keep the narrator nameless serves as a narrative device that intensifies her sense of anonymity and reinforces her lack of a distinct identity
- The lack of a name also contributes to the narrator's initial feelings of insignificance and invisibility:

Stuck on something?

Ask questions and get help with exactly what you're revising.

Got it

revered by everyone at Manderley
    - Her namelessness symbolises a loss of **autonomy** and illustrates the societal expectations and norms that constrain the narrator's self-perception
- It could also be interpreted that the narrator is meant to forge her own identity in the present:
    - One that is free from the constraints imposed by societal expectations and the haunting memory of Rebecca
    - It further reinforces the idea that her identity is not defined by a name but by her experiences and the strength she gains throughout the course of the narrative

- There is a continual interplay between the present and the past:
    - The novel begins in the present, moves to the past and then returns to the present
    - Furthermore, the narrator's dreams and memories add to the non-linear structure of the text and also its unreliability

Help me understand

Examiner Tips and Tricks

Remember that the people in the text are conscious constructs, and so are the places being described and the objects mentioned. Try to learn to notice deliberate things du Maurier has done to communicate her ideas.

As you read the text, try to consider: "why this, now?" For instance, du Maurier uses a circular structure within the novel. Try to consider why she may have done this.

Bildungsroman

- The Bildungsroman genre originated in Germany and directly translates to a "novel of education":

- It generally portrayed the protagonist's psychological and moral growth

- The conventional structure of a Bildungsroman involved the following:
    - **Loss:** The protagonist experiences a profound emotional loss at the beginning of the narrative
    - **Journey:** Motivated by their personal tragedy, the protagonist embarks on a journey, either physical or metaphorical, to gain a better understanding of the world
    - **Conflict and personal growth:** The protagonist's journey entails mistakes and often clashes with societal norms, though as the narrative progresses, the protagonist gradually embraces the values of society

which denotes maturity
- The novel is narrated in the first person, which presents a personal and subjective account of the narrative

- Rebecca could be viewed as containing some elements of a bildungsroman as the narrator goes though a personal journey of self-discovery:
  - Bildungsroman is a genre of novel that charts a protagonist's development (in this case from immaturity to maturity)

- The narrator recounts her past as a young and experienced woman, newly married to Maxim de Winter
- Her development and transformation is marked by her wish to understand and define her own identity:
  - Her confrontation with the truth forces her to reassess her preconceived notions and perceptions

- As the narrative progresses, the narrator overcomes her insecurity and embraces her individuality:
  - The mature narrator recounting the narrative in retrospect is now no longer haunted but exudes a greater understanding of herself and is more self-confident

The Gothic

- Du Maurier incorporates Gothic elements into Rebecca:
  - This could be used to critique the oppressive structures of **patriarchy** and aristocracy prevalent in 20th-century Britain

- Similar to the traditional Gothic tradition, the setting itself becomes a character and influences the tone of the narrative:
  - Manderley's secluded and isolated location adds to its mysteriousness
  - The house is surrounded by dense forests and the sea, which underscores its isolation and a sense of confinement
  - There are also descriptions of hidden corners and secret passages, which underscores the idea that Manderley holds many secrets

- Rebecca's spirit adds a supernatural element to the narrative:
  - The narrator experiences vivid dreams and hallucinations related to Rebecca, which adds to the supernatural element:
    - These blur the boundaries between reality and the supernatural and align to the Gothic tradition where the subconscious becomes a realm for exploring fears and desires

  - The circumstances surrounding Rebecca's death are also shrouded in mystery

- As a character, Maxim aligns with the Gothic tradition as a character haunted by their own emotions and the

    - This aligns to the Gothic genre where the heroine experiences isolation and alienation

- Mrs Danvers is consistently depicted using imagery associated with death:
    - She is described as "tall and gaunt…a skeleton's frame…her hand was limp and heavy, deathly cold, and it lay in mine like a lifeless thing"
    - This portrayal implies a metaphorical loss of life for Mrs Danvers following Rebecca's death

- The novel is set in the Manderley estate, surrounded by misty landscapes and turbulent seas:
    - For example, during moments of confusion and melancholy for the narrator, a fog often descends
    - On the night that Maxim kills Rebecca, there is a storm

Symbolism

- Du Maurier establishes Manderley as a symbol of the upper **echelons** of society in 20th-century England:
    - Manderley itself serves as a symbol of the past and the haunting legacy of Rebecca

- Du Maurier infuses a Gothic atmosphere into Manderley and employs elements such as descriptions of eerie surroundings and hidden passages
- Ben's mental disability and his dwelling in a beachside cottage could be seen as symbolising the neglect and decay within the Manderley estate
- The ball and the use of costumes and masks is used to symbolise the characters' attempts to conceal their true selves:
    - The narrator's symbolic use of the same costume as Rebecca symbolises the character's struggle with her identity

- The west wing of Manderely is used to symbolise the secrets and knowledge surrounding Rebecca's life and death:
    - Its discovery by the narrator marks a turning point in the narrative

- Rebecca's untouched room is used to symbolise her enduring legacy and influence that exists at Manderely:
    - For Maxim, the room becomes a constant reminder of the past and the secrets that remain at Manderley

- The sea is often depicted as mysterious and tumultuous:
    - It serves as a foreboding symbol and contributes to the ominous atmosphere

Suspense genre

- Truth remains elusive throughout much of the narrative and many characters are linked to deception and secrets,

establishes an atmosphere of suspense
- The novel gradually reveals secrets and keeps the reader in suspense as they uncover the secrets surrounding Rebecca's death:
  - The specific circumstances surrounding Rebecca's death are shrouded in mystery throughout the narrative
- The revelation of Maxim's secrets and the complexities of his relationship with Rebecca add a layer of ambiguity to his character:
  - One of the major twists in the narrative is the revelation of Rebecca's true nature:
    - Her sinister and manipulative actions challenge the reader's preconceptions
- The plot takes an unexpected turn towards the end of the novel when legal proceedings become a central focus:
  - The outcome of the investigation into Rebecca's death becomes uncertain and raises questions about the fate of the characters

Examiner Tips and Tricks

In the exam, the question will involve the command word "how" and will make reference to the author. This invites you to explore the craft of writing/the writer's methods and go beyond the "what" of the text to thinking about the text as a conscious construct, exploring what the writer has done on purpose to create meaning.

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